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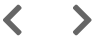
Artist in Action

Artists in Action: Unique rest stop planned along the Chief Ladiga Trail

By Hervey Folsom, Artists in Action

Jun 21, 2025

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A plan for a new and unique type of rest stop along the Chief Ladiga Trail is in the making by Matt and Heather Headley.

The Headley Flower Farm, in north Anniston, is ten acres of land they have been cultivating since 2021. They will provide a new recreational event: putting trail travelers in touch with fresh flowers, history and hospitality.

“We’re raising flowers, our kids and community, inviting others to slow down and bloom,” said Matt, expressing the couple’s purpose. Once the farm is opened to the public and a short foot bridge connects the trail to the farm, the site will be a new opportunity for outdoor fun and learning.

But there's much more to know about the Headleys and their shared life of a ministry in music.

Matt most recently served Anniston's First United Methodist Church as Director of Music. Before that he was pastor at First United Methodist Church in Weaver. A vocalist and guitar player, Headley earned his Bachelor of Arts in Music at Jacksonville State University in 2009 and his Master of Divinity degree at Northern Seminary (in Chicago) in 2014. Heather, a pianist, also earned her Bachelor of Music degree at JSU.

Matt has now taken a new path in life. In his case, the path leads from the Ladiga Trail to the Trail Shop, with views of a flower field, pecan trees, their historic home and a greenhouse. The Headleys also see their front porch, 500 feet from the trail opening, as a future space for music and storytelling.

The Trail Shop is a kiosk for flowers, juice, salads and sandwiches provided by A Quality Farms of Anniston. The Headleys will also supply information about other sites to see in the community.

The Flower Farm is a boutique flower farm, growing specialty cut flowers in the Saks area of Anniston. Heather, the chief gardener here, is the planter and fills orders for floral designs for wedding, special events or celebrations. Heather and Matt plan to host on-farm workshops and farm tours.

HistoryThe farmhouse style home was built in 1832, the year that a group of land speculators bought 320 acres of land from the Creek Indian Chief Ladiga, according to The Jacksonville News. edition Nov. 26, 1832. This house was constructed before Jacksonville was incorporated.

Genealogy added a boost to their mission. The name “Headley” is of old English origin, meaning “heather meadow.”

“Maybe this was meant to be!” Heather said.

From seed to bloom Flowers, an integral part of our lives, evoke beauty and new life with their blooms. Brides carry them, churches request them and they are a part of almost every celebration. Snapdragons — anemone, a member of the buttercup family — and ranunculus, a favorite with gardeners are the colorful flowers we’ll soon be seeing.

Matt is originally from Oxford and Heather, from Pleasant Valley. Their children .Soren, Sage, Noah and Hannah seem settled in as Matt has transitioned from music director to farmer. The work is demanding, but getting close to nature is a blessing, Matt believes his vocation could become a ministry. .

“For me this is a sanctuary,” Heather said and Matt agrees. “I want this to become a destination.”

Calhoun County Community Art Show • July 18 — Aug. 8 The deadline for entries in the 2025 Community Art Show at Jax State is June 30. The annual show is coordinated by the Jacksonville Arts Council and Jax State Department of Art & Design. Any resident of Calhoun County of any age may enter. All mediums will be accepted. For entry forms, visit www.jsu.edu/art/html

Tags

Chief Ladiga Trail

Ranunculus